

NETRIMONY



FORGET HOROSCOPES. IGNORE CASTE. ONLINE MATRIMONIAL SITES ARE CHANGING THE RULES OF THE MATING GAME AMONG URBAN YOUTH AND BECOMING AN ELECTRONIC VEHICLE FOR SOCIAL CHANGE IN INDIAN SOCIETY.

Online matrimony is worth **Rs 140 crore**, up from Rs 58 crore in 2006

Visitors moving to the Net for matrimony up from **15% last year to 48%**

Over **12 million** Indians use online matrimonial searches

Matrimonial sites are now the **13th most popular mainstream** online activity

There are nearly **20 million** members worldwide for the leading two sites alone

One million success stories and **50 testimonials a day** from happy couples for a top site

■ By Damayanti Datta

Kalpana Swamy, a single girl who shifted to Mumbai, recently wrote a three-page letter to her mother which said: "Dear mom, this is to counter the flood of cvs of suitable boys you are sending. It's irritating to read about people who don't excite me. Living alone in Mumbai has changed the girl who left home four years ago." She did not want a "good boy" from a "good family", with matching caste and horoscope and reeled off her priorities: "He has to be smart, sensible, sincere, sensitive and qualified enough to lead a better life." A busy brand consultant, Swamy enjoys her work so the man in her life needed to respect that. "Wavelengths need to match. Compatibility and chemistry matter the most to me," was the final caveat.

It reflects a new mindset among the urban youth in India and a major reason for that is the Internet and the large number of matrimonial sites offering a new landscape for romance and the search for a life partner without the traditional trappings or restrictions. It's instant, it's convenient, it's anonymous. It's a powerful tool for discovering compatibility and it's fuelling an increasing number of successful marriages. The

wide range of Indian matrimonial sites is also engineering a major social change. Such sites have been around for a while but never in such large numbers and offering such a wide range of options and services. Millions of unmarried couples, especially young women, are now depending on the Net to exchange photos, videos, views and opinions before bringing in the parents to convince them they have found the person they want to marry. It's a major development in a society where mobility and opportunity is separating parents from their children much earlier than before.

At last count, there were over 100 such sites. India has some 38.5 million Internet users and nearly 60 per cent are below the age of 25. Of them, 48 per cent are registered with matrimonial sites, 51 per cent with dating and friendship sites and 37 per cent of Internet users are into both the activities. The year-on-year growth for matrimonial services is 130 per cent, while that of dating sites is 88 per cent.

The Internet has become "a vehicle of social change", writes Bridgette Colaco of the Southern Illinois University in her 2007 study, *Internet Dating in India*. In a country where pre-marital relationships are usually frowned upon, "the Internet offers India's urban youth the opportunity to

WHAT WOMEN WANT

68% To work after wedding **41%** Favour intercaste marriage **62%** NRI husbands